GUIDE FOR AUTHORS · 2027

# How to get your book into bookstores in 2027

SHORT ANSWER

Bookstores order from wholesale catalogs, not from authors. Make your book **orderable** first: an ISBN under a publisher name, clean metadata and a listing with the wholesalers stores already use. Then make it **worth stocking**: terms the trade accepts and a reason for a store to believe its customers will buy it.

START HERE

# How bookstores actually buy books

Bookstores order most of their books from wholesalers. One account covers thousands of publishers, with one invoice and fast delivery.

### Catalogs, not inboxes

Booksellers search wholesale catalogs that list millions of titles. They do not browse author websites or answer cold emails.

### Terms the whole trade uses

A store buys below the list price, expects a trade discount and often the option to return unsold copies.

### Same route for every book

A self-published book reaches a bookstore the same way as any other: listed where booksellers order, on terms they accept.

THREE MARKETS, AS OF OCTOBER 2026

# Where bookstores order in the US, the UK and Germany

### United States

Stores and libraries order through the catalogs of the major book wholesalers. Baker & Taylor announced in October 2025 that it would cease operations.

### United Kingdom

Wholesalers such as Gardners, which keeps about 500,000 titles in stock for same-day dispatch. Publishers register with Nielsen BookData.

### Germany

Barsortimente – Libri, Zeitfracht and Umbreit – deliver overnight. Titles are looked up in the VLB, the directory of available books.

BEFORE ANYONE CAN ORDER

# Five things a bookstore needs from your book

Without the first three, the book cannot be ordered at all. Without the last two, it can be ordered but is unlikely to be stocked.

- **An ISBN and a publisher name** – it identifies the edition and puts it into Books in Print
- **Wholesale availability** – through the wholesaler the store already buys from
- **Returnability** – many booksellers only buy books they can send back
- **Complete metadata** – title, author, format, price, date, subject categories
- **A trade discount** – the store lives on the difference to the list price

THE KEY DISTINCTION

# Orderable is not the same as stocked

Print on demand makes a book orderable wherever the wholesaler reaches. A store only puts copies on its shelf if it expects them to sell.

Every copy on a shelf is money the store has already spent.

WHY IT RARELY HAPPENS

# Why most self-published books never reach the shelf

### No sales machinery

Traditional publishers bring sales reps, seasonal catalogs, advance copies and budgets. A self-published title usually arrives with none of these.

### Terms that shift the risk

A book that is non-returnable or carries a short discount can be orderable, but the store takes all the risk on every copy.

### No known publisher

A publisher the store knows, listed with its usual wholesaler, makes the yes much easier.

### Special orders still count

A customer asks, the store orders one copy, the customer picks it up: a real sale through a real bookstore.

PART 1

# Make your book orderable

These three steps decide whether a bookseller can order your book at all.

01

## Get an ISBN under a publisher name

The ISBN and the imprint travel with every record a bookseller sees. See what a publishing imprint is.

02

## File complete metadata

Title, author, format, price, publication date and subject categories, in the directories of every market you sell in.

03

## Get listed with the wholesalers

Stores order on the account they already have. If your book is not in that catalog, the usual way to order it does not exist.

PART 2

# Make your book worth stocking

Being listed opens the door. These steps give a bookseller a reason to walk through it.

04 **Offer terms the trade accepts**

A real trade discount and returnable status are the first things a buyer asks about.

05 **Give one store a local reason**

A local subject, a reading, a signing or a talk turns a maybe into a few copies on display.

06 **Send readers to ask for it**

Every reader who asks for your book in a store brings it closer to the shelf.

THE MOST ASKED-FOR CHAIN

# How to get your book into Barnes & Noble

What B&N's own help pages say, as of October 2026.

### Listing comes from data

B&N lists titles from bibliographic data the publisher supplies: ISBN, title, author, publisher, format, price, date, BISAC and discount.

### Send it early

The record goes to B&N ideally at least 180 days before publication.

### No paid placement

B&N states it will never offer in-store placement for your books in exchange for money.

### The route in

Wholesale distribution under a publisher, listed in the catalogs B&N stores already order from.

INDEPENDENT BOOKSTORES

# Consignment: what to get in writing first

The store takes a few copies without paying upfront and pays you for the ones that sell. Terms differ from store to store.

- The split between you and the store
- How long the books stay on display
- What happens to damaged or unsold copies
- Any intake or handling fee
- How and when you are paid
- Works best with a local subject, an event or a reading group

IN PERSON

# How to pitch your book to a local bookstore

**01** **Go at a quiet time**

Ask who handles ordering. Bring a copy of the book.

**02** **Bring a one-page sheet**

ISBN, price, format, publisher, a short description and how the store can order it.

**03** **Be a customer first**

Booksellers notice who supports their store.

**04** **Know your terms**

Discount, returnability and wholesaler are the first questions a buyer asks.

**05** **Offer something**

A reading, a signing or a talk gives the store a reason to stock and promote copies.

**06** **Accept a no**

Shelf space is limited, and a store's decision about its own shelves is final.

WHY BOOKSTORES ARE DIFFERENT

# Catalogs, not star ratings

### On Amazon

A self-published book is found through its sales, and its reviews decide whether readers buy. With few reviews, one one-star rating pulls the average down.

### In the book trade

A bookseller looks at the publisher, the ISBN, the price and the terms. No reviews or ad budget are needed for a store to order your book.

WITH SHELF PUBLISHER

# Where a Shelf Publisher paperback can be ordered

**50,000+**

bookstores order from the catalogs your book is listed in

**18**

countries, through print on demand

**8–9 days**

until a book usually shows up in stores and online

Retailers that order from these catalogs include Barnes & Noble, Bookshop.org, Walmart, Foyles, Blackwell's, Thalia, Hugendubel, Orell Füssli, laFeltrinelli, Booktopia and Amazon (each checked by ISBN search, October 2026). They are retailers, not partners.

BOOKSTORES PER MARKET

# Orderable wherever readers ask for it

**27,000+**
bookstores in the United States

**9,500+**
bookstores in the United Kingdom

**6,800+**
bookstores in Germany

**4,200+**
bookstores in France

Plus Spain (3,100+), Italy (3,000+), Canada (1,400+) and 12 more countries. Source: shelfpublisher.com/get-your-book-into-bookstores.

TWO ROUTES

# Selling only to readers, or letting the trade reorder

## Self-publishing alone

- Sells almost only to readers on Amazon
- Bookstores and wholesalers rarely order it
- Without ads, sales usually stall

## With Shelf Publisher

- Published under the Orbita Media imprint, with an ISBN
- Listed in the catalogs bookstores order from
- Stores order, readers buy, stores reorder
- Print on demand: no warehouse, no stock risk

INCLUDED PER BOOK

# What Shelf Publisher does for each paperback

- An ISBN, so you do not buy one
- Publication under Orbita Media as publisher
- Print on demand, ordered and monitored for you
- Your copyright stays yours
- Your metadata filed with the directories of your markets
- Setup with the distribution channels
- Revenue collected, quarterly statements and payouts
- All rights come back to you when the contract ends

QUESTIONS

# Getting into bookstores, answered

### Do bookstores buy books directly from authors?

Usually not. Most stores order through wholesalers so they can buy many publishers' books on one account. Some independent stores take local authors' books on consignment.

### Will bookstores put my book on their shelves?

Every store that orders from these catalogs can order it, for a customer or for its own shelf. What a store keeps on the shelf is the bookseller's choice.

### Can a print-on-demand book be sold in bookstores?

Yes. Listed with a wholesaler, it can be ordered by any store that uses that wholesaler. Whether a store keeps copies on the shelf depends on the terms and expected demand.

### How long until my book appears in stores?

With Shelf Publisher, usually about 8 to 9 days after you submit it, in most cases within two weeks; some retailers take longer.

NEXT STEP

# Put your paperback where booksellers order every day

Shelf Publisher is invitation only. Our publishing team reviews every request personally.

**Request access to Shelf Publisher**

Get your book into bookstores  Full guide: how to get your book into bookstores  How it works  Free book spine width calculator

# Sources

1. Shelf Publisher: Get your book into bookstores
2. Shelf Publisher: How to get your book into bookstores (guide)
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